



Learning Space

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

TRANSFER OF POWER MODULE-1 (REVISED & NEW)





The Times of India



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PRICE TWO ANNAS

NO. 133, VOL. CIX.

BIRTH OF INDIA'S FREEDOM

NATION WAKES TO
NEW LIFE

For Big
People

STATE VISIT TO KARACHI

FRENZIED ENTHUSIASM
IN BOMBAY

Crowds In Festive Mood

THE national flag was hoisted over the 14-year-old
Bombay Civil Secretariat at midnight when the citizens
greeted the dawn of the new day with singing
and cheering.

AUGUST 15, 1947



POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

TRANSFER OF POWER



LEONARD WOOLF
BRITISH POLITICAL THEORIST



- 1 India got **independence on 15 August 1947**, thus ending the British rule. The end of the British rule was long overdue. Leonard Woolf was of the opinion that **had the transfer of power been done earlier** or the relaxations and the provincial governments were granted earlier, the transfer would have been a lot more peaceful.
- 2 We had been asking for independence from before as was evident from the resolution of **Purna Swaraj or complete independence**.
- 3 The way this day of Purna Swaraj was celebrated was **different from the day of actual independence** because independence was accompanied by Partition.

ABOUT '15 AUGUST 1947'



CLEMENT RICHARD ATTLEE
PRIME MINISTER, UK
(1945 - 1951)

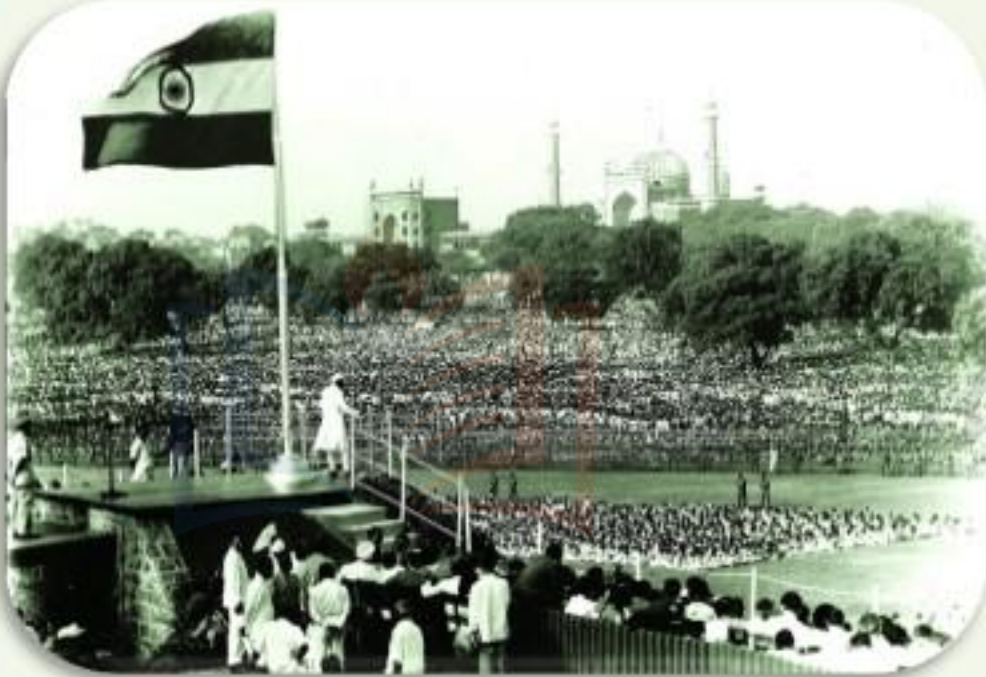


LORD MOUNTBATTEN

- PM Atlee Offered dominion status to the successor authorities.
- On 20 Feb 1947- Majesty's Government announced intention of transferring power by June 1948.
- The Cabinet Mission had failed to evolve a Constitution that would be acceptable to India.
- 15 August 1947 was chosen as the day of transfer of power and granting independence by Lord Mountbatten as it was the second anniversary of the Japanese surrender to the Allied forces in the Second World War. This day, thus, catered to imperial pride.
- Some astrologers in India did not find '15' an auspicious day. So, they started the celebrations of independence shortly before midnight.

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

CELEBRATION OF INDEPENDENCE



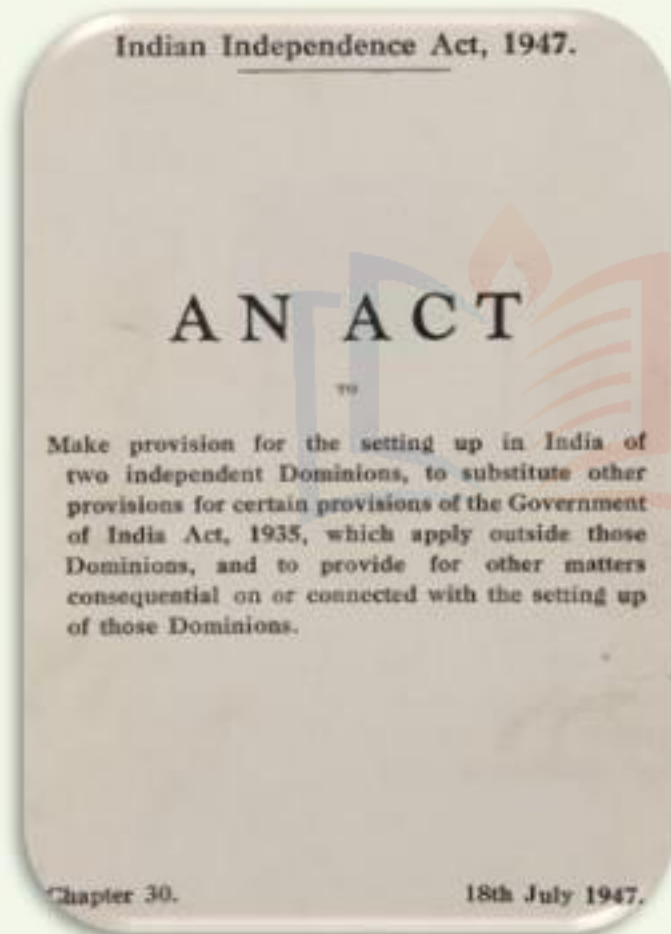
Flag hoisting took place in different parts of the country and were symbolic in several ways:

- In **Benaras**, Indian tricolor was **hoisted by a Muslim**.
- In **Shillong**, it was **hoisted by two young men** to show that new India would include participation of Young India.

British had decided to transfer in India to an authority who it felt was largely accepted by the people.

INDIAN INDEPENDENCE ACT

Based on the Mountbatten plan of June 1947, the Indian Independence Act was passed in July 1947.



According to this Act:

- On 15 August 1947, the country would be **partitioned into India and Pakistan**.
- India and Pakistan would have **Dominion status** and powers would be transferred to the respective governments.
- The Dominions were to **constitute Constituent Assemblies to frame the Constitution** of their respective countries.
- The **Boundary Commission would decide the borders** between India and Pakistan.
- **British suzerainty over the princely states would end** on 15 August 1947 after which they were free to decide to join either of the two dominions or to remain independent.

WHY WAS INDIA PARTITIONED?



The unity of India could not have been saved because of three reasons:

- **Congress** underestimated the motivations and actions of Jinnah and the Muslim League.
- **Jinnah** pursued the goal of a separate country regardless of human consequences.
- British promoted the policy of **Divide and Rule**.

FAILURE OF CONGRESS



- In 1930, **JL Nehru** was of the opinion that the Muslims would support a **socialist society instead of supporting a party based on religion**.
 - In 1930, Jinnah requested Congress to make a deal, but **Muslim League's requests were ignored**.
 - By the 1940s, it managed to gain the support of a large section of the Muslims of the country.
 - Earlier, Jinnah was known to be a **supporter of Hindu-Muslim unity and a believer in constitutional politics**. But that stance changed soon.
 - Among other social upheavals in the country: **Tebhaga agitation** took place in the Telangana region in the Princely State of Hyderabad by the **share-croppers**. The **Communist Party of India** led the uprising.
 - **Naval mutinies, industrial labor strikes** took place in several parts.
- These created additional pressure on the Congress.

STANCE OF MUSLIM LEAGUE



- **Electoral politics** further strengthened these religious identities.
- By 1944, the Muslim League had half a million members from Bengal, including Muslims from all sections of the society.
- In **1940**, Muslim League gave the final call for the formation of Pakistan.

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

MUSLIM LEAGUE – 1946 ELECTIONS



- In the 1946 elections, the Muslim League instilled fear that if the Muslims failed to get a separate homeland, they would be crushed by the Hindus in a united India.
- The elections were thus a referendum in support of a separate state of Pakistan.
- The League urged the voters to overcome sectarian divisions and unite under Islam.

- In the seats reserved for Muslims, the Muslims won 74.7 percent votes.
- Violence spread in Calcutta as Hindu-Muslim riots took place on Direct Action Day declared by the Muslim League.
- These riots later spread to United Province, Bihar and Punjab. Jinnah wanted to force the British to divide India.

16 AUGUST 1946 - DIRECT ACTION DAY



THE CROWD THAT ATTENDED THE MEETING



- Muslim League and Congress did not agree to the conditions under which the provinces would leave or join the Indian Union.
- **Cabinet Mission failed** to reach any settlement on 29 July. Muslim League called for Direct Action Day on 16 August.
- The **landowning families of the Muslims in Punjab and Sindh supported an independent Pakistan**. The **poor peasants of East Bengal also supported it**.
- It is believed that the idea of Pakistan was proposed by **Indian Muslim students of Cambridge University in 1930s**.

WAS JINNAH CORRECT?



- Some critics point out that since **large number of Muslims were left in India even after creation of Pakistan**, Jinnah simply wanted to use the demand for a separate state as a bargaining chip to win greater control over Muslims within India.
- This is also because the idea of Pakistan was not thought of until late 1930s.

WRONGDOINGS OF BRITISH



- British encouraged these religious divisions. The introduction of **communal electorates** was an example in this regard.
- After the Second World War, Labor government came to power in Britain **and wanted to speed up the process of transfer of power** in India.

The logic given by the British: *"It was easier to divide the India against Hindu wishes than to unite India against Muslim wishes".*

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

WHY DID THE BRITISH TRANSFER POWER?



- The devastation caused by the **Second World War** made it **difficult** for Britain to **sustain** and control British India.
- The country was affected by the **Great Depression** leading to **inflation and mass unemployment**.
- Bengal was hit by a **famine in 1942**.
- The widespread **violence of Quit India movement** further pressurized the colonial powers.

WHY DID THE BRITISH TRANSFER POWER?



Muhammad Ali Jinnah, Liaquat Ali Khan, and Jawaharlal Nehru with Viceroy Mountbatten during a meeting on June 2, 1947

- On 20 Feb 1947, the labor government in London announced that the British would quit India by June 1948.
- In **March 1947, Viceroy Mountbatten assumed office.** They understood the **inevitability of the state of Pakistan.**
- Several plans were made around this new state including the 800-mile long corridor through India linking East and West Pakistan.

WHY DID THE BRITISH TRANSFER POWER?



- On 3 June, Lord Mountbatten announced the transfer of power in the middle of August 1947.
- The reason was that since the Partition was inevitable, it was about time that the transfer of power happened soon as communal riots would soon spread across the country.

The British did not want it to happen under the British rule.

POST INDEPENDENCE DEVELOPMENTS

HASTY AND UNPLANNED PARTITION



- This hasty decision, however, led to more deaths. The **Governor of Punjab urged Mountbatten to reconsider the decision.**
- The **army was deputed in areas of European settlements** for the protection of the British officials and their families instead of controlling the riots.
- As for the announcement of the Boundary Award, Mountbatten postponed the announcement of Punjab after the transfer of power **because they did not want to take responsibility for the lawlessness which they though would engulf the nation.**

Had the award been announced earlier and army had been deployed for their management, the process of partition might have been less ghastly.

LIMITATION OF BOUNDARY AWARD



Justice Radcliff was appointed to implement the Boundary award and demarcate the boundaries between dominions of India and Pakistan.

- Justice Radcliff had no prior knowledge about India.
- He had no specialized knowledge needed for the task also.
- He had no advisors and experts.
- 6 week deadline that Radcliff had was also a limitation of this award.



JUSTICE RADCLIFF

PARTITION ... PROBLEMS

1

- **No single Muslim majority** area in British India as two major concentrations of East and West and scattered areas with Muslim population (Enclaves in India and Bangladesh).
- So **Pakistan had two parts**
 - ✓ **East**, and
 - ✓ **West** with India in-between.

2

Not all Muslim majority areas wanted to be in Pakistan- Leader of North Western Frontier Province also known as **Frontier Gandhi** **opposed the two-nation theory**.

3

Muslim majority areas had non-Muslim populations as well. So the two regions which were to be known as Pakistan would be further divided on the basis on Religious majority but not immediately- so people unsure which area they belonged to.

PARTITION ... PROBLEMS

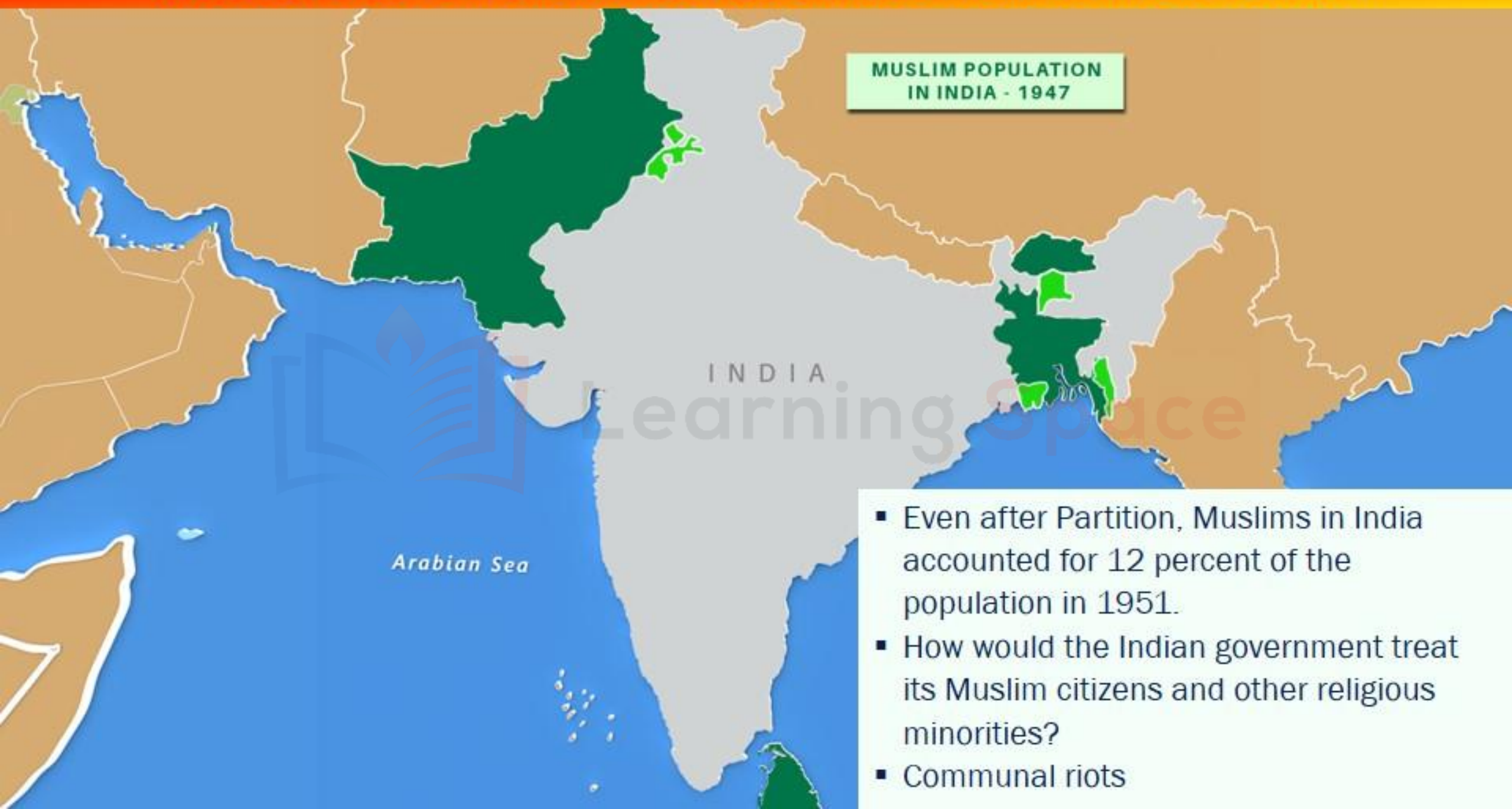


4 **Minorities on the border areas**- trapped in a country with a different religion- emotional question of leaving their ancestral land. They were being attacked by the majority of the areas- tragic transfer of population.

5 No plan by the political elites to manage the situation- **ad hoc refugee camps, local administration and police not helpful.**

6 **Mass level of killings and suffering**- worst affected were the women- division of properties, assets and administrative apparatus.

DID PARTITION ON RELIGIOUS BASIS MAKE INDIA A HINDU NATION?



- Even after Partition, Muslims in India accounted for 12 percent of the population in 1951.
- How would the Indian government treat its Muslim citizens and other religious minorities?
- Communal riots

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